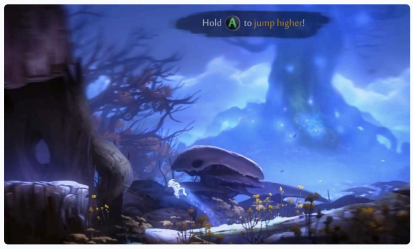
LEVEL & UX DESIGN RESEARCH

Comparative Analysis Report: Tutorial Level Design

Domain: Player Onboarding & Tutorial Flow **Benchmarks:** Rayman Legends, Ori and the Blind Forest, Animal Well

1. Market Analysis of Benchmark Titles

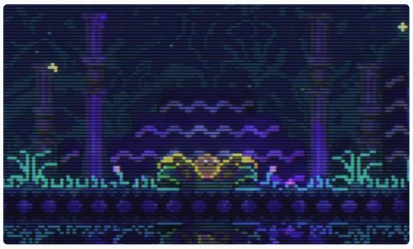
To refine our onboarding structure, we analyzed three titles known for unique and effective tutorial execution: *Rayman Legends*, *Ori and the Blind Forest*, and *Animal Well*. The shared design foundation across these benchmarks is the delivery of contextual mechanical prompts at precisely engineered moments (e.g., an insurmountable barrier requiring a charged high jump in *Ori*, an obstructive bulbous mushroom prompting an attack in *Rayman*, or an opening cocoon compelling a jump to break free in *Animal Well*).



Ori: "Hold (A) to jump higher!"



Rayman: "Press (X) to hit"


Animal Well: "[X] jump"

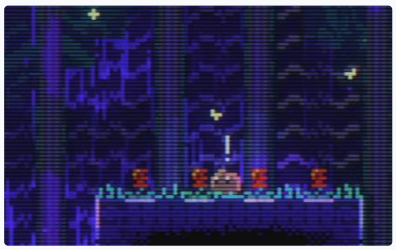
A. Animal Well – Experimental Model (Trial-and-Error Learning)

In a conventional sense, *Animal Well* lacks a dedicated tutorial level due to its continuous Metroidvania map topology. Nevertheless, its introductory biome functions as an implicit tutorial. The opening space is devoid of active hazards, allowing players to assimilate movement and jumping physics in complete safety. Following the initial save telephone, the path transitions to a linear corridor introducing the first enemy encounter, enforcing learning through observation, trial, and failure.

A prominent demonstration is the firecracker mechanic: picking up the asset provides zero text description regarding its usage. Instead, developers grant a surplus supply for exploratory usage alongside clear environmental cues – a previously impassable monster blocks forward progress, inherently guiding the player to deploy the explosive as a defensive deterrent.



Found Firecracker dialogue overlay


In-game pickup prompt icon

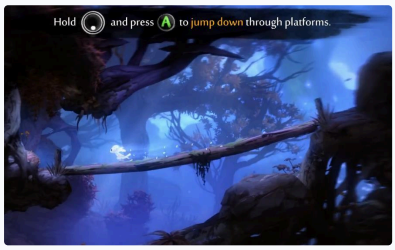

Predator encounter requiring firecracker use

B. Ori and the Blind Forest & Rayman Legends – Explicit Instructional Model

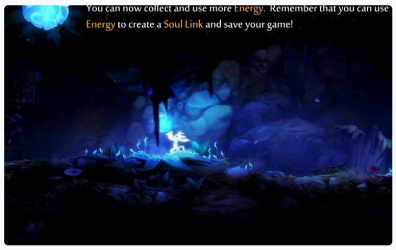
In contrast to *Animal Well*, these two productions focus on direct, unequivocal communication of core game rules and interaction controls.

Ori and the Blind Forest

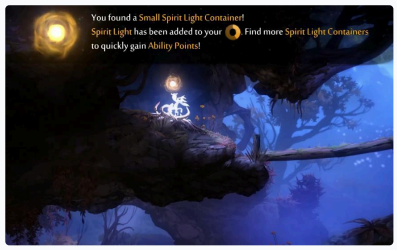
Explains fundamental as well as complex mechanics explicitly from the very onset to encourage deliberate player execution. Mechanics are layered sequentially: players spend time in harmless spaces to practice mechanics before adversaries appear in strictly controlled sandboxes for low-stress combat mastery.



Platform drop-down input prompt



Energy Cell & Soul Link save tutorial



Spirit Light Container explanation

Rayman Legends

Employs high-contrast visual cues indicating the required input and anticipated outcome. Its introductory stage focuses on graded difficulty pacing. Instead of mobile enemies, the player first confronts stationary turnips. The density of active adversaries scales progressively, concluding at approximately 90% hazard density. The sequence breaks down into five deliberate phases:

- **Phase 1: Introduction** – Foundation traversal coupled with primary melee attacks.
- **Phase 2: Pop Quiz (Skill Check)** – Verification of learned commands against mobile hostiles.
- **Phase 3: Companion Assist** – Introduction and tactile coordination with the Murfy mechanic.
- **Phase 4: Parkour Gauntlet** – Demanding platforming layouts testing traversal precision.
- **Phase 5: Mechanical Synergy** – Composite end-of-stage gauntlet demanding concurrent traversal, combat, and companion execution.



Turnip uproot combo prompt



Companion eye-poke contextual cue



End-of-stage composite synergy trial

2. Comparative Benchmark Matrix

Tutorial Phase / Quality Indicator	Market Standard (Analyzed Reference Titles)	Current Project Implementation
1. Information Clarity	Unambiguous button glyphs accompanied by succinct action feedback (*Rayman*, *Ori*).	**Needs Refinement** Short text prompts exist, but visual prominence and readability remain suboptimal.
2. First Contact (Orientation)	Isolated, threat-free starting zone allowing players to adapt to character locomotion.	**Implemented** Map provides an isolated starter pocket to learn basic movement.
3. Core Skill Verification	Focused skill-check validating fundamental mechanic retention prior to progression.	**Implemented** Dedicated section confirms basic comprehension.
4. Mechanic Layering	Sequential introduction of advanced interactions across subsequent rooms.	**Implemented** Stepwise rollout of environmental assets (oil, cassette).
5. Final Examination (Synergy)	Composite challenge raising mechanical friction to baseline campaign intensity.	**Missing** Difficulty fails to ramp toward campaign expectations; no composite gauntlet exists.

3. Recommendations for Level & UI Designers

- **Implement a Capstone Trial (Synergy):** Design a climactic section at the end of the tutorial stage with elevated difficulty. This room must require the player to simultaneously coordinate dashing, piston hazard avoidance, and object manipulation (oil can, cassette), ensuring smooth skill transfer into Level 1.
- **Overhaul Tooltip & Input Legibility (UI/UX):** Rebuild the visual layout of contextual prompts. Increase contrast and readability (e.g., dark semi-transparent backplates, clear typography, and platform-accurate controller button icons) modeled after the clear visual presentation in *Rayman Legends*.